

BEST

Management Advice

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“USE NAY-SAYERS’ NEGATIVE ENERGY TO FIRE YOURSELF UP”

Q Young female managers start their careers with a promising future but begin to stagnate by the time they reach middle management. What can companies do to remove this anomaly?

It is less about what companies can do and more about our personal choices. In mid-career, some women face a dilemma of priorities between their jobs and home. I believe societal pressures and norms compound this. However, those of us who have had supportive family systems have managed to juggle both. In my book, “30 Women in Power: Their Voices, Their Stories”, they share how they built crucial support systems. However, companies can help with flexi hours, work-from-home policies, and attract women back to work after they leave an organisation.

Q Impact of AI on Indian businesses?

AI is impacting jobs, productivity, investment at



an unprecedented level. But adoption of AI often fails in practice. Frontline employees struggle due to lack of skills, access to tools, leadership guidance, and time. This creates an execution gap. We need AI that is responsible, outcome-driven, scalable, data-led, and people-centric. We must also clearly articulate the human capabilities that remain paramount: creativity, judgment, empathy, and strategic direction.

Q More than twenty years back, you

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joined the global board of Nestle SA. I believe it was an exceptional case. How did that

come about?

I joined the global board of Nestle in 2005 when I was scheduled to take over as CEO of HSBC India in 2006. At HSBC, we were permitted to join only one other external board. I would urge all companies to encourage this. Call it luck or happenstance, I was the second woman ever to join the Nestle global board and amongst the first Indians on the board of a Fortune 100 company. Possibly my expertise in the area of finance, emerging markets experience and working in multi-cultural environments, played a part.

Q What are the lessons from your career that others can emulate and learn from?

Determination to overcome obstacles—indeed, using the nay-sayers’ negative energy to fire up oneself; ability to attract and work with diverse teams; awareness of my several shortcomings but recognising that the buck stopped with me; never forgetting the true north of values and integrity; passion, enjoying work, hard work, and a sense of humour are some of the factors that I have worked towards in my career. **BT**

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